nation'. [121] Unlike his mother, Rajiv was prone to verbose speeches where he would state that the path India had chosen was 'unique',[122] that India's 'stock' in the world was high and that Indian policy was to 'carve out the right path and reach the principles and ideology of Gandhiji to all corners of the world'.[123] For Rajiv, India's Weltanschauung was 'shaped by our history, our traditions and values of our civilization'.[124]

The Nehruvian idealist in Rajiv championed disarmament with a passion, which echoed his grandfather. In November 1986, India and the Soviet Union signed the Declaration for a Nuclear-Weapon- Free and Non-Violent World. The declaration spoke of the need for peaceful coexistence, supremacy of human life, non-violence, political and economic independence and using resources for social and economic development, not military resources.[125] Still, as a pragmatist, Rajiv also stated that while India did not want to accumulate arms or build nuclear weapons, the international system was such that India had no option but to divert resources to strengthen itself. That is how he justified India's nuclear test of 1974, under his mother's leadership, and why India had not unilaterally abandoned the quest for nuclear weapons.[126]

Foreign policy under Rajiv Gandhi was a personalized affair in which the prime minister was the main actor. This echoed the conduct of his mother and grandfather. Rajiv changed his foreign minister often, going through five external affairs ministers and seven ministers of state for external affairs during his five years as prime minister. His lack of confidence in his first foreign secretary led him to discontinue the traditional weekly meeting between the prime minister and the foreign secretary and to even publicly dismiss his own foreign secretary in the midst of a press conference. Seeking to implement drastic change in a system that was oriented towards status quo and with which he was not very comfortable led Rajiv to seek outside advisers or trust his own views instead of those of an entrenched bureaucracy.